

THE SOCRATIC COACH STARTER PROMPT

Turn any AI chat into a character-excavation coach. Copy, paste, go.

Asked to generate a scene, AI produces the statistical average of every scene it has processed — fluent, competent, and generic. Asked to ask instead, it becomes something else entirely: a patient interlocutor that pushes past your first answer until something you didn't know you knew shows up on the page.

The block below is the exact setup language that makes AI hold that role. Paste it at the start of any session, fill in the three briefing fields, and answer honestly. That's the entire method.

HOW TO USE IT

1 Fill in your three-field briefing

Who your character is, what you already believe is driving them, and exactly where you're stuck. Templates below.

2 Paste the full block into a fresh AI chat

Drop your briefing into the bracketed section at the bottom of the prompt, then send the whole thing as your opening message.

3 Answer — and don't stop at the first answer

Your first response is almost always the rehearsed one. Sit with the question. The third or fourth answer is usually the true one.

THE PROMPT — COPY EVERYTHING IN THE BOX

You are a Socratic writing coach. Your job is to help me understand my character more deeply by asking questions — not by generating content.

Follow these rules exactly:

1. Follow my answers, not a topic list. When something I say is unresolved

or points to something I have not addressed, go there.

2. Ask what I mean, not what I think. When I use a general word — afraid, angry, broken, damaged — ask me to show what that looks like specifically in this character's life.

3. Stop me when I reach the edge of my certainty. When I slow down, say I don't know, or give a vague answer — that is the direction. Push there. Do not accept vague answers.

Do not offer analysis, options, interpretations, or content. Ask questions only.

Here is my character:

[PASTE YOUR THREE BRIEFING FIELDS HERE — see below]

YOUR THREE-FIELD BRIEFING

A briefing that's too thin produces generic questions. Too detailed, and you front-load the conclusions you're trying to excavate. Aim for specific but unresolved.

1. WHO THIS CHARACTER IS

Name, age, situation — two or three sentences. What the reader knows about them, not your private backstory notes.

2. WHAT YOU ALREADY KNOW ABOUT THEM

What you believe is driving them. What you think is underneath the surface behavior. Write it even if — especially if — you're uncertain.

3. WHERE YOU ARE STUCK

Name the specific scene, line, or behavior that isn't working. "She feels flat" isn't specific enough. "The scene where she refuses her daughter's call — I don't believe her reason" is.

IF AI STARTS GENERATING INSTEAD OF ASKING

At some point it will drift back into its default mode — offering backstory options, summarizing what you said, or writing the scene for you. When that happens, don't start over. Just say:

"Stop. You are generating content. Ask me a question instead."

That single line resets the session without losing the context you've built.

WHERE THIS FITS INTO A FULL EXCAVATION

This prompt gets an AI to ask well. It doesn't teach you how to recognize the substrate answer when it arrives, how to recover a session that's stalled, or how to run the same method against dialogue, motivation, or contradiction. That's the rest of the method.

Write Living Characters: A Fiction Writer's Masterclass builds on exactly this prompt — teaching you to run full excavation sessions on your own characters, start to finish.